



Qualitative analysis of forgiveness towards parents and examination of connections to current romantic relationship in adults from children's homes

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ABSTRACT

The primary goal of this study was to find out how adults raised in children's homes perceive and experience forgiveness toward their parents, specifically their mother and father. The secondary goal was to examine any connections between them forgiving their parents and their current romantic relationship. The sample consisted of 10 individuals raised in children's homes, with an average age of 25.7 years ($SD = 3.2$) and average length of romantic relationship of 3.2 years ($SD = 1.03$). Data were obtained by semi-structured interview and analyzed using Consensual Qualitative Research (Hill & Knox, 2021). Participants understood forgiveness mainly as the absence of negative emotions and as moving forward. The main motivation for forgiving one's parent was discussions with children's home staff and volunteers, but also exhaustion from negative feelings. An important aspect of the forgiveness process was understanding the parent and their life. The process of forgiving one's mother and father was similar; however, participants experienced greater difficulty forgiving their father and were more willing to reconcile with their mother. The consequences of forgiveness were described mainly in terms of an absence of negative feelings and achieving inner peace. Participants also stated that forgiving a parent was associated with greater satisfaction in their romantic relationship, more open communication and being more understanding of their partner. The results of this study reveal the importance of forgiveness in the lives of people raised in children's homes, not just in terms of overall quality of life, but also quality of romantic relationship and healing relationships with parents.

1. Introduction

According to Act no. 305 (2005), a children's home is a setting created and run for the purposes of complying with court orders placing children in institutional care, interim care and requiring child-rearing. Children's homes are a temporary substitute for the child's natural family setting or substitute family setting.

A substantial number of studies (e.g. Salifu Yendork & Somhlaba, 2015; Shulga and Filinkova, 2016) show that children who grow up in children's homes frequently have psychological, social, and academic difficulties. Diagnoses such as depression (Jozefiak et al., 2016) and post-traumatic stress disorder (Keller et al., 2010) are common, as is impaired academic performance (Trout et al., 2008) and various serious problems such as substance abuse (Traube et al., 2012) and suicidal behavior (Taussig et al., 2014).

Overcoming the difficulties associated with being placed in a

children's home is often painful, with the children having to process a number of negative feelings. Children who grow up in institutional care can have complicated relationships with their parents as they often perceive being placed in a children's home as an act of abandonment by their parents (Courtney & Heuring, 2005). Research has shown that children, adolescents, and adults who were raised in children's homes often experience feelings of anger, resentment, and hatred toward their parents (Moslehuddin & Mendes, 2006). Forgiveness represents one of the adaptive ways of dealing with the painful emotions associated with a difficult past, such as anger and resentment, and it also helps to repair interpersonal relationships (Enright & Fitzgibbons, 2015). Enright (2001) defines forgiveness in terms of reducing negative feelings and increasing positive feelings about the offender, where the victims are willing to relinquish their right to resentment while showing undeserved compassion, generosity, and even love towards them, even when the offender does not deserve it. Others (McCullough, 2000; Rye et al.,

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2001) similarly state that forgiveness involves two aspects: the absence of negative emotions and a reduced desire to avenge or avoid the offender; and the presence of positive emotions toward the offender. There is controversy over whether forgiveness involves the development of positive feelings and thoughts towards the offender, or whether it is simply the absence of negative thoughts and feelings (Exline et al., 2003). In contrast to these scholars, Thompson et al. (2005) define forgiveness as freeing oneself from the attachment to the source that has harmed us and does not necessarily involve positive feelings about the offender. This definition is supported by Berez (2001), who sees forgiveness as letting go of pain and bitterness from the past.

The process of forgiving is often long and emotionally demanding. It is even more difficult if the harm is caused by a parent who should be the child's "safety net" and a source of close emotional attachment. Škoviera (2007) states that children growing up in care homes may deal with this experience through revenge, anger, harboring motives of unforgiveness and by experiencing a number of negative feelings that often prevent forgiveness. One of these factors may be unrealistic views of the past, such as idealizing it, clinging to past experiences, and constantly blaming oneself or others. Such fixations on the past may lead to delayed child development and reduce the potential for reconciliation with the past and the betrayal experienced. By contrast, accepting and understanding the past, as well as the circumstances under which the harm occurred are appropriate attitudes to the past. Vadrna (2018) states that children who are abandoned may face difficulties owing to feelings of guilt associated with non-acceptance and rejection. Parental rejection often leads children to feel that no one else will be able to accept them. Hurtful parental behavior is also associated with negative effects such as depression, anxiety and anger or low self-esteem (Coates & Messman-Moore, 2014; Win et al., 2021) and may lead to such children constantly seeking attention or love from others. Needs such as love or parental care are often not met and a feeling of loneliness and rejection accompanies such people in adulthood, significantly affecting their relationship with others and themselves (Vadrna, 2018). Forgiveness represents an opportunity to come to terms with the past and to develop appropriate attitudes toward the past, and this may have an important effect on the person's functioning in life and later relationships (Škoviera, 2007).

Most research on interpersonal forgiveness has examined this phenomenon in close adult relationships, be they romantic or marital (e.g. Timothy-Springer & Johnson, 2018; Sheldon & Antony, 2019). However, since all relationships differ in function and type, scholars argue that the process and purpose of forgiveness also depends on the relationship context in which the forgiveness occurs (Maio et al., 2008). Thus, previous research on forgiveness in close adult relationships may not be sufficient for understanding parent-child forgiveness. Unfortunately, this topic has received considerably much less research attention. Therefore, the main problem in our study is the lack of research findings on forgiveness toward parents in adults raised in children's homes, as well as ambiguous differences in forgiveness toward mother and father. Based on these facts, our primary goal is to find out how adults raised in children's homes forgive their parents, focusing specifically on forgiving the mother and forgiving the father. Given the lack of previous research findings, the secondary research goal is to examine the relationship between adults raised in children's homes who forgive their parents and their current romantic relationship.

While definitions of forgiveness differ, most scientists agree that forgiveness differs from several other related constructs, such as justification, forgetting or reconciling (Enright & Kim, 2015; Freedman & Zarifkar, 2016). In her research, Drábíková (2011) focused on forgiveness in young adults who were raised in a children's home for part of their lives. The results showed that participants tended to confuse forgiveness with reconciliation, restoration of trust, understanding the other or forgetting. Given that the concept of forgiveness is often confused with other concepts, our first partial aim is to examine how adults raised in children's homes understand the concept of forgiveness

and what the concept means to them. We therefore ask the following research question: *Q1: How do adults raised in children's homes understand the concept of forgiveness?*

Although researchers are exploring the ways in which children cope with problematic interactions with parents, they mostly focus on younger children and adolescents (Christensen et al., 2001; Paleari et al., 2003). Hence there is a need for a deeper examination of forgiveness toward parents in adults. The existing literature provides inconsistent evidence on whether there are any differences between forgiving one's mother and forgiving one's father. Maio et al. (2008), for example, reported differences in forgiveness in the person's relationship with their mother versus their father, arguing that these differences are influenced by evolutionary principles that condition the separation of the father from children. However, a study by Hoyt et al. (2005) produced mixed results on whether there is a distinction between adolescent forgiveness of the mother and the father. One study, involving adolescent boys and girls, suggested that adolescents had different motivations and perceptions of forgiveness in their relationships with their mother and father. By contrast, a second study of 12- to 14-year-old adolescent girls found no differences in perceptions of and motivations for forgiving their mother and father. In order to better understand the experience of forgiveness in specific family relationships, we decided to focus our research on forgiveness towards mothers and fathers and analyzing any potential differences. We therefore asked ourselves the following research questions:

What was the participants' experience of forgiving their mother (Q-2) and their father (Q-3)?

What factors influenced the motivation of the participants (not) to forgive their mother (Q2-a) /their father (Q3-a)?

What was/is the process of forgiving the mother (Q2-b)/father (Q3-b)?

What factors help/prevent individuals from forgiving their mother (Q2-c) / their father (Q3-c)?

What consequences do participants think (not) forgiving their mother has on their life (Q2-d)? What consequence do participants (not) forgiving their father has on their lives (Q2-d)?

Q4: Are there any differences between forgiving one's mother and forgiving one's father?

Conger et al. (2000) stated in their longitudinal research that there is a significant association between the child-parent relationship and the romantic relationship in adulthood. Research (Akhtar & Barlow, 2018; Braithwaite et al., 2011) has shown that forgiveness is essential to improve mental well-being and repair relationships. We therefore wondered whether there was a link between adults raised in children's homes, their relationship with their parents, forgiveness and their romantic relationships. As the last partial goal was to examine the relationship between the participants' current romantic relationship and forgiveness toward their parents, we asked the following research questions:

Q5: What are participants' perceptions of their current romantic relationship?

Q6: Are there any connections between the participants' current romantic relationship and forgiveness toward their mother (Q6a) / toward their father (Q6b)?

2. Method

2.1. Sample

Our research group consisted of ten people raised in children's homes. Given our research aims, the first criterion for participating in the research was a history of growing up in a children's home. The age limit was set at 20 to 35 years, and participants had to have been in a romantic relationship for at least two years at the time of the research, as research shows that passionate love, also called "being in love", gradually declines in a romantic relationship after approximately two years

(García, 1998) and a stable relationship is formed. That relationship is characterized by physical and emotional intimacy, devotion, and feelings of safety and security (Acevedo & Aron, 2009). Five women and five men participated in the research and the age of the participants ranged from 20 to 28 years, with an average age of 25.7 years ($SD = 3.2$). The participants had been placed in a children's home at age three to seven ($M = 4.7$; $SD = 1.42$) and length of stay ranged from 13 to 20 years ($M = 15.2$; $SD = 1.93$). All participants were in a romantic relationship at the time of the data collection and the average length of relationship was 3.2 years ($SD = 1.03$).

2.2. Data collection

We used snowball sampling as the recruitment technique. We contacted five acquaintances who met the research criteria. These participants then provided us with the email addresses of other people, whom we contacted and asked if they would like to participate in the research. Data were collected through semi-structured interviews. As the pandemic situation did not allow us to meet the participants in person, the data collection was carried out online via video calls. After joining the video call, participants were informed about the research aims, anonymity, the voluntary nature of their participation, and told they could end the interview at any time. They were also informed that the interview would be recorded for transcription purposes. All participants signed an informed consent and sent it to us. All procedures performed in this study were in accordance with the ethical standards and with the 1964 Helsinki declaration and its later amendments or comparable ethical standards. Furthermore, the interviews were led by a master's psychology student, who had the appropriate training and experience of working with children from children's homes, having volunteered for six years under the supervision of a skilled psychologist with many years' experience of working with this target group. Participants were also given contact details for psychologists/therapists with whom they could continue working on any issues that may have come up during the interviews. However, none of the participants made use of this opportunity since they did not feel they needed help: these issues were not new to them – they had previously dealt with them in counseling, therapy, or lectures. In addition, participants took part in a debriefing conversation and all of them stated that it had been a pleasant experience and that participating in the study had been meaningful. Moreover, the interview was not a trigger since they had already been working on these issues with psychologists.

The interviews lasted an average of 60 min, including a final debriefing conversation. Participants answered the following main questions: *If you can, how would you describe forgiveness? Have you ever considered forgiving your mother? If so, what motivated you to start working on forgiveness / decide to forgive? What was the process of forgiveness like? What helped you forgive? What did you find difficult and problematic when forgiving your mother? Do you think forgiving your mother has had any consequences on your life?* The same set of questions was applied to forgiving the father. Then the following questions were asked: *Do you think there were any differences between forgiving your mother and father? How would you describe your current romantic relationship? Do you think there is any connection between your romantic relationship and forgiving your mother / father?*

2.3. Data analysis

We used Consensual Qualitative Research (CQR) by Hill and Knox (2021) to analyze the data. In CQR open-ended questions in semi-structured interviews are used to gather consistent data from the participants and to examine their individual experiences. It requires a team of researchers who bring different perspectives to the analysis process before reaching a consensus and at least one auditor whose role is to check the work of the research team and thus minimize the effects of group thinking (Hill, et al., 2005). In our case, the team consisted of two

psychology students and an auditor, a university lecturer with experience of qualitative research, who provided feedback on the data.

After the data gathering, the interview recordings were transcribed, and in order to maintain participant anonymity, all identifying data about the participants were removed and the interviews were marked Adult 1, Adult 2, etc.

The interviews were first split in half, with both team members analyzing the first half of the interviews independently. The subsequent analysis consisted of several phases. The members of the research team first segmented the data into domains and then identified the core ideas in the domains. This was followed by a cross-analysis of the first half of the interviews, in which each member of the team independently created categories/subcategories into which the main ideas were classified based on content similarity. The last step was the selection of a representative statement for each category/subcategory. The members of the research team met after each of these steps in order to discuss the differences until a consensus was reached. The results were then sent to the auditor, and once the comments had been incorporated, the second half of the interviews were analyzed, following the same procedure in cases where the core ideas fitted into the established categories/subcategories, or a new category had to be created. The members of the research team evaluated how the new cases saturated the categories. The saturation was attained after six cases, as adding the last four cases did not bring any changes in categories structure. Once the members of the research team had reached a consensus, the final data analysis was sent to the auditor and her comments were subsequently incorporated into the results, which are reported below.

3. Results

The first research question examined the adults' understanding of the concept of forgiveness and, based on their answers, we created a domain called *Understanding of the Concept of Forgiveness* (Table 1). The most numerous categories in this domain were the *absence of negative emotions* and *letting go, moving forward*. The participants described forgiveness as when the person stops suffering and no longer feels anger, guilt or hatred, which means they can move on with their life. For eight participants, forgiveness also meant the *presence of positive emotions*, mainly in terms of *composure* with oneself and all the bad things that happened, feeling *at peace, free, and liberated*. Forgiveness was seen not only at the emotional level, but also in terms of cognition, such as the *absence of reoccurring thoughts*, a *reduced desire for revenge*, but also understanding for the other person and accepting the situation.

The categories in the concept of forgiveness, presented by our participants, can be further divided into higher dimensions: emotional (absence of negative emotions; letting go; presence of positive emotions); cognitive (absence of repetitive thoughts; understanding the other person; accepting the situation), and behavioral (reduced desire for revenge). Based on the frequency of the answers, we can see that our participants exhibited the emotional component of forgiveness most, followed by the cognitive component; the behavioral component did not present strongly.

The second research question focused specifically on the adults' experiences of forgiving their mother and their father, and, based on their answers, we derived five domains.

The first domain was *Motivation to Forgive One's Mother and Father* (Table 2). The most common category relating to both parents was *conversations*, either with the children's home staff or volunteers. In both cases, the participants said that, through such conversations, they gradually began to understand that they were carrying around the pain they were supposed to deal with, and also began to understand what forgiveness really meant. An equally important motivational factor in forgiving both parents was *exhaustion from negative feelings*. Individuals were motivated in particular by the fact that they could no longer be angry since being angry at their parents "pulls them down in life" and drained them of energy. One participant described an inner need to

Table 1

Domain – Understanding the Concept of Forgiveness.

Category	Subcategory	Representative statements	TK
Understanding the concept of forgiveness	Absence of negative emotions 9/10	I would describe forgiveness as when a person stops being angry and does not feel disappointed with or hatred for the other.	T
	Letting go, moving forward 9/10	...when, in spite of the guilt, the person moves on in life.	T
	Presence of positive emotions 8/10	Composure 4/10 ...when I feel composed within myself and all the bad things that have happened.	T
		Peace 4/10 I think true forgiveness should bring peace to the person's soul.	
	Absence of repeated thoughts 6/10	Feelings of freedom 4/10 I think you feel lighter and freer after forgiving.	
		I don't need to keep bothering myself with the thought of it, constantly replaying the guilt in my head.	T
	Reduced desire for revenge 5/10	... I have no desire to avenge the one who hurt me.	T
Understanding the other person 3/10	Understanding the other person 3/10	...understanding the actions of the person who hurt me.	VR
	Accepting the situation 3/10	That I accept all the bad things that have happened ...	VR

Note: TC = typology of categories; G = general; T = typical; VR = variable. Participant responses translated by team members from Slovak into English.

forgive that got to the point where he had to draw a line under everything, and he did that by forgiving.

Five participants stated that they felt the need to forgive their mother and their father after *changing their view on forgiveness*. They stated that they had to first understand what true forgiveness really meant and that forgiving did not mean forgetting or having to reconcile with others. It was also important for them to understand how not forgiving was affecting their lives. Some participants mentioned *belief in God* as an important factor motivating them to forgive their mother and father. One motivational factor that was specific to forgiving one's father was *the importance of their relationship with him*. They stated that they had only one father and therefore did not want to lose him because of their inability to forgive him.

The second domain we created was the *Process of Forgiving One's Mother and Father* (Table 3). The first general category was *understanding*. Most of the participants stressed the importance of *understanding their parent, their situation, imperfection and life*. Participants stated that once they began to empathize with their parent and look at the situation through their eyes, they felt sorry for them rather than anger and hatred. Understanding *the meaning of forgiveness* was also important during the forgiving process, as participants began to see forgiveness as a path to healing and life change. It was also important for them to understand

Table 2

Domain – Motivation to Forgive One's Mother and Father.

Category	Subcategory	Representative statements	TK
Motivation to forgive one's mother	Conversations 8/10	Staff at the children's home 6/10 And I was led to do so by employees at the children's home and our psychologist...	T
		Volunteers 6/10 When we went to the camps on these topics, I felt such an impulse to oh, that something needs to be done about it, because I will not end up in the best way.	
	Exhaustion from experiencing negative feelings 8/10	Also, the fact that I couldn't be angry anymore, I couldn't keep up the anger and hatred toward my mother. I felt that it was a lot for me and that I wanted a different life.	T
	Change in perception of forgiveness 5/10	I started to look at it completely differently, and I realized that I, not my mother, needed the forgiveness.	T
	Faith 5/10	I also believe in God, so I needed to forgive my mother from the spiritual point of view.	T
	Conversations 9/10	Staff at the children's home 8/10 ...psychologists, educators were also a great help.	T
		Volunteers 6/10 The volunteers helped because they paid a lot of attention to similar topics. We had lectures, and we could discuss everything in much more depth than at the children's home	T
	Exhaustion from experiencing negative feelings 8/10	And it also motivated me, being tired of the hatred, I needed to find a way out, somehow ... and that was forgiveness.	T
	Change in perception of forgiveness 5/10	I was mainly motivated by the knowledge that it was me, not my father who needed forgiveness. That he didn't have to be involved in the whole process and that I didn't even have to tell him. That it's really just about me.	T
	Faith 4/10	And I believe in God, too, so my overall thinking didn't sit	VR

(continued on next page)

Table 2 (continued)

Category	Subcategory	Representative statements	TK
Importance of relationship with one's father 2/10		well with what I believed.	VR
		To lose the only father I have? We're all just the way we are, after all.	

Note: TC = typology of categories; G = general; T = typical; VR = variable. Participant responses translated by team members from Slovak into English.

their *own feelings*. They needed to understand what they actually felt and why they felt that way so they could make progress in forgiving.

Decision to Forgive was mentioned by six participants when talking about forgiving their mother and by four participants when talking about forgiving their father. Participants stated that their decision to forgive was initially mechanical and that first they said they were forgiving their parent, even though they did not feel they were. When describing the process of forgiving their mother and father, participants typically mentioned the benefits of forgiveness, mainly that it brought equilibrium, freedom and relief. Three participants mentioned their relationship with their mother improve, while none did so in relation to their father. Also, four participants mentioned *changing their opinion of their mother*. Four participants said they gradually experienced *pity, compassion*, for their mother as part of the process of forgiving, as soon as they were able to understand their mother's situation and that she did

not have it easy in life either. Those four participants mentioned that *reconciliation* with their mother was part of the forgiveness process. One participant, for example, described a powerful moment when she met her mother and told her that she forgave her. She added: "My mother was crying and I felt a great deal of sympathy for her, that I was not really the only one who was suffering and who was carrying the burden. Suddenly we were in it together."

Interestingly, none of the participants mentioned changing their opinion of their father and becoming reconciled with him as part of the forgiveness process. On the other hand, they stressed *the difficulty of forgiving*. Half of the participants felt *anger* and three participants said their *own stubbornness* was a problem, because their father appeared uninterested and they could therefore see no reason why only they should work on forgiving. Three of the participants could not stop *blaming their fathers*, which greatly complicated the forgiveness process, and three participants stated that they felt great *hatred* toward their father.

The last category was *the perceived difficulty of forgiving*. Four participants stated that especially at the beginning it was very difficult to decide to forgive their mother and work on forgiveness (for three participants this also applied to the father) and that the process took a very long time. Although only four participants explicitly mentioned the difficulty of the process, it is clear from the context of the interviews that the other participants also found forgiving their parent was a difficult, long and not linear process with many setbacks and sometimes they even felt like they did not even forgive at all and needed to start all over again with the forgiveness process.

Table 3

Domain – Process of Forgiving One's Mother and Father.

Category	Subcategory	Representative statement	TK
Process of forgiving one's mother	Understanding 10/10	Mother, her situation and life 9/10 Meaning of forgiveness 8/10 Own feelings 6/10	G
	Decision to forgive 6/10	I decided to forgive, so in the beginning I just said to myself "I forgive you, I forgive you, I forgive you," even though I didn't believe it.	T
	Benefits of forgiveness 6/10	There really was a change in the relationship, or a deepening of it, for which I am infinitely grateful. It brought me great relief.	T
	Changing their opinion of their mother 4/10	I finally saw a huge personal growth in myself. Then I gradually started to feel sorry for my mother, because she really didn't have it easy in life, so who am I to judge?!	VR
	Reconciliation 4/10	I just take her the way she is, with all the mistakes, because no one is perfect. I was able to come to terms with my mother, which was the end point after forgiving. I didn't need it, but I'm glad it came.	VR
	Perceived difficulty of forgiving 4/10	Oh, it was hard, very hard. It was long, it was difficult, I couldn't take it sometimes.	VR
	Understanding 10/10	But I also just said to myself that he was just human, that he was raised like that too, and he just couldn't raise me differently, that he didn't have people around him to help him find his feet and live differently.	G
Process of forgiving one's father		Gradually, I began to understand that forgiveness was about my own development and moving forward in life, and that the longer I was angry and stubborn, the longer I was hindering myself from developing.	
	Benefits of forgiving 8/10	I understood how I actually felt and why I felt like that. Now I'm completely balanced and fine with all those feelings. I see it as such a release from the chains. It's great that I don't blame myself anymore and that I don't blame him either.	T
	Difficulties in forgiving one's father 7/10	I accepted everything with gratitude. I was exhausted from the hatred and anger. I was so stubborn, like why should I forgive him when he doesn't even come to see me at children's home ... why should I try and he won't do anything? So at first I really struggled with the idea that I should try to forgive him at all. I blamed him for everything that happened to me in my life. I hated him for everything that happened.	T
		I just decided to forgive him.	VR
	Decision to forgive 4/10	Well, at first I couldn't even imagine thinking about such a thing at all, the hatred, anger and remorse wouldn't allow me to at all.	VR
	Perceived difficulty of forgiving 3/10		

Note: TC = typology of categories; G = general; T = typical; VR = variable. Participant responses translated by team members from Slovak into English.

The third domain was called *Factors Aiding Forgiveness toward One's Mother and Father* (Table 4). As mentioned in relation to the previous domains, the factor that most helped participants forgive their parent was *understanding* the parent and their life situation, understanding the meaning of forgiveness and their own feelings; as well as *conversations* with staff and volunteers. Three participants found that *prayer* was also important in helping them forgive their mothers. Three participants mentioned writing *a letter to their mother* that was never sent. The letter helped them they relinquish all their negative emotions and freely express what they felt. They also found that reading the letter over time helped them see changes in their experience with forgiveness. The ability to *empathize with their father* helped two participants reduce their feelings of anger.

The fourth domain is *Factors Preventing Forgiveness toward Mothers and Fathers* (Table 5). The most numerous category with regard to the mother was *negative feelings toward her*, especially anger, hatred, but also *disgust*. Another typical category was *mother's lack of interest*. Participants said it would be easier if their mother apologized, or if they could see she was sorry for what they had had to go through. The most important factor preventing participants from forgiving their father was their own *stubbornness*, and five participants give this reason in relation to their mother. The adults could not accept that they had been left to grow up in a children's home while their parents were "outside" and not interested in them. Five participants also mentioned *self-pity and victim status*, which they thought were a comfort to them that was difficult to give up.

Half of the participants also commented on the *lack of regret, apology*, when talking about how difficult it was for them that their father had never apologized or asked for forgiveness. Anger and hatred also blocked them from forgiving their father.

In the fifth domain *Consequences of Forgiving One's Mother and Father* (Table 6), we identified four identical categories relating to forgiving one's mother and one's father. The most numerous categories were *mental health* and *personality change*, but also *social benefits*, which had a slightly higher representation for the father.

Participants described *mental health benefits* of forgiving in terms of an inner balance and a life balance, as well as the absence of negative feelings. They stated that they were no longer burdened by feelings of anger and hatred and that they no longer felt nervous, anxious and tense all the time. Half of the participants continued to feel overall satisfaction in their lives, as well as being satisfied with themselves and their relationships, and had an inner peace and freedom. Participants also noticed that forgiving led to a *personality change*. They began to be more open to others and more accepting of their own imperfections. Their self-esteem increased, they were able to better regulate their emotions and they also experienced overall personal growth.

Forgiveness also led to important *social benefits*. Participants described *improved relationships* with others, whether with family members, with the parent, their romantic partner or friends. They said they were finally building healthy relationships that they worked on and enjoyed. Two participants also noted the importance of *trusting people*, which they had not done before forgiving.

The last category, *physical health*, and was mentioned by three participants. They said they felt physically lighter and more relaxed and no longer suffered from constant fatigue and exhaustion.

In the fourth research question, we examined whether there were any differences in the way participants forgave their mother and father. From that data, we created the domain *Differences Between Forgiving One's Mother and One's Father* (Table 7). The most numerous category within this domain was *forgiving one's father is more difficult*. Six

Table 4
Domain – Factors Aiding Forgiveness toward One's Mother and Father.

	Category	Subcategory	Representative statement	TK
Factors aiding forgiveness toward one's mother	Understanding 10/10	Mother, her imperfections and her situation 10/10	It also helped me when I started thinking more about what my mother went through and why she wasn't showing any interest in me. And gradually I realized that there was nothing more human than not having the strength to go on.	G
		Meaning of forgiveness 7/10	And it also helped me realize that the forgiveness is about myself, that maybe if I met my mom now and told her I forgave her, maybe she wouldn't care, but still it was really about me and my life.	T
	Interviews 9/1	Own feelings 6/10	I was beginning to understand that I was suppressing something I should work on.	T
		Volunteers 6/10	...without all the conversations with the volunteers, I'd probably be angry still and I'd be drowning in self-pity.	T
	Prayer 3/10	Staff at the children's home 4/10	So for me, clearly all the people in the children's home, the educators, the psychologists, they were a great support.	T
		Mother 2/10	It certainly helped that mom and I talked about everything. I also prayed a lot, so the silence in prayer was helpful for me.	VR
Factors Aiding forgiveness toward one's father	A letter to the mother 3/10		I also wrote a letter to my mother, but I didn't give it to her, so it was always such a strong moment for me when I read the letter after a few months to see what had changed in me or something ...	VR
			But it was certainly most helpful when I realized that my father was just ill. That he had been ill all his life and that it was mainly transferred from his parents to him. I began to see him completely differently.	G
	Understanding 10/10	Father, his imperfections and his situation 9/10	It was great for me really educating myself, going to all kinds of lectures and just really understanding what forgiveness really means. Because you think you know, but before that I thought that forgiveness was about the other person saying sorry to you, then everything is forgotten, you have no right to be angry in any case and then you shake hands, your relationship heals and you move on. Of course, that's not the case at all.	
		Meaning of forgiveness 7/10	...so I gradually came to the conclusion that the anger wouldn't solve anything, that no one would take it away from me. I needed to understand that, that if I forgive, it doesn't mean it's okay I ended up in a children's home.	
	Interviews 9/10	Staff at the children's home 6/10	It also helped that I had someone to talk to, that I had such professional guidance, psychologists, educators in the children's home, that they had my back.	T
		Volunteers 6/10	The weekend courses were a help, where we discussed a lot about forgiveness and various other topics about the relationship with my parents.	
	Empathy 2/10	God 3/10	...conversations with God helped me a lot.	
			And probably the fact that I'm quite a sensitive person, I felt empathy towards my father.	VR

Note: TC = typology of categories; G = general; T = typical; VR = variable. Participant responses translated by team members from Slovak into English.

Table 5
Domain – Factors Preventing Forgiveness toward One's Mother and Father.

	Category	Subcategory	Representative statement	TK
Factors preventing forgiveness toward one's mother	Negative feelings toward one's mother 7/10	Anger 4/10	I was extremely angry with her every time we met.	T
		Hatred 3/10	I was falling asleep with all those feelings of hatred.	
		Disgust 2/10	I felt really disgusted at her for a long time.	
	Mother's lack of interest 6/10		The feeling that my mother didn't care I was worried and that I was trying to forgive her at all was also a big barrier.	T
	Stubbornness 5/10		And the worst part was my stubbornness, which was probably the hardest thing for me to overcome.	T
	Self-pity, victim status 5/10		The problem was that when I imagined not being able to pity myself any longer, it was as if I had lost a lot of my identity. That "hurt" status was a big part of me. If I wasn't hurt, then who was I?	T
	Feelings of injustice 2/10		It was difficult to deal with the feelings of injustice, such as "why me"?	VR
	Stubbornness 6/10		...such childish stubbornness and the fact that I didn't want my anger to be taken away from me, that I had a right to be angry, so why should I let that feeling go.	T
	Self-pity 5/10		It was difficult to let go of self-pity, I felt a certain comfort when I could feel sorry for myself.	T
	Absence of regret, apology 5/10		It was difficult that he never said sorry, he didn't apologize either, he wasn't sorry, at least that's what it looked like in my eyes.	T
Factors preventing forgiveness toward one's father	Negative feelings toward one's father 5/10	Anger 5/10	I'd been feeding that anger for a long time.	T
		Hatred 3/10	... because I really hated my father.	VR
	Blaming one's father 3/10		So I blamed him more, I handled the idea of forgiveness a lot worse.	VR
	Father's disinterest 2/10		... the feeling that my father doesn't care when he didn't even go to see me at children's home, so I felt so alone again... that he doesn't even care if I forgive him. So it was quite difficult.	VR

Note: TC = typology of categories; G = general; T = typical; VR = variable. Participant responses translated by team members from Slovak into English.

participants stated that they found forgiving their father more difficult because they were angrier with him and blamed him more for the fact they had had to grow up in a children's home. Two participants found forgiving their father more difficult because he had a drug and alcohol problem, and one participant stated that the whole process of forgiving both parents was long and hard, but that it was easier for him to forgive his mother because he could see some interest from her but not his father.

For two participants, forgiving *their mother was more difficult*, as that relationship was worse and they were angrier with her. For one of them, forgiving was more difficult partly because she showed no interest in seeing them.

Two participants *did not think there were any differences* between forgiving their mother and father: it was just as difficult and it took them just as long to forgive both parents.

The last fifth research question examined whether there was any link between the participants' current romantic relationship and forgiving their parents.

Within the first domain, *Association between Current Romantic Relationship and Forgiving One's Mother* (Table 8), we identified five categories. Each of the categories concerned the perceived changes to their relationship once they were able to forgive their mother. *Positive change in aspects of the relationship* contained all the perceived positive changes to the participants' current relationship, such as overall relationship satisfaction. One participant said that had he not forgiven her he would not have been able to form an authentic relationship. Four participants mentioned understanding their partner, being able look at things through their eyes and empathizing with them (e.g., P6, man: "... if I hadn't tried to understand my mother, I wouldn't be able to understand my partner, I wouldn't be able to see things through her eyes, to look at problems from the other point of view"). Also, four participants said that they felt much more open in their relationship because they no longer kept things to themselves.

Another important category was the *positive change in personality*. Six participants began to value themselves much more, which, they said, was reflected in their satisfaction in the relationship. One participant specifically stated that because she had forgiven her mother she could function in a healthy relationship.

Six participants also reported that the *positive change in emotions was reflected in the relationship*. Participants said they were no longer nervous, angry and irritated all the time, and that was positively reflected in their partner relationship. Three participants regulated their emotions more as a result of forgiving their mother.

In the second domain, *Association between Current Romantic Relationship and Forgiving One's Father* (Table 9), we identified four categories. The category of *positive changes in aspects of the relationship* applied to eight participants. Five participants stated that one of the biggest changes for them was *openly communicating* with their partner, which was a radical change from the way they had communicated before forgiving their father. Four participants felt more satisfied in their relationship and three were trying to make the relationship work well. They attributed the fact that they were not giving up on the relationship to forgiving their father. Two participants also cited trust as a key change, saying they could not have trusted their partner if they had not forgiven their father, as they would see their father's disappointment in their partner's actions and expect the same hurtful behavior.

The second most numerous category, a *positive change in emotions, not projecting the hurt onto the partner*, related to eight participants, who said that if they had not forgiven their father, they would not be able to enjoy all the good that comes out of the relationship. They said that as soon as they forgave their father, they felt light in their life, and this was reflected in the quality of the relationship with their partner, as they no longer projected all their bad feelings onto their partner.

Table 6

Domain – Consequences of forgiving one's mother and father.

	Categories	Subcategories	Representative statements	TC
Consequences of forgiving one's mother	Mental health 9/10	Feelings of balance 6/10	Now I'm generally at peace with myself, my mom, the past.	T
		Absence of negative feelings 5/10	I'm no longer burdened by all those negative feelings toward my mother.	
		Satisfaction 5/10	I'm much more satisfied with life.	
		Inner peace 5/10	I feel much more of an inner peace now.	
		Feelings of freedom 5/10	I am more relaxed, freer, it makes me happy to live, literally.	
	Personality change 9/10	Openness 4/10	I think as I forgave, I became more sociable and open.	T
		Better regulation of emotions 4/10	I'm more prudent, not everything gets to me, I can control myself. Before that, I was irritated non-stop, I was just waiting for someone to make me angry.	
		Self-acceptance, self-esteem 4/10	And certainly in relation to myself it has improved, I am okay with everything that has happened and I like myself, which wasn't easy before.	
	Social benefits 7/10	Improved relationships 6/10	There's much more peace in my life, whether in relation to my mother or my relationships with others.	T
		Trust in people 2/10	I could start trusting the people around me because I understood that we are all just people and we are all fallible.	
Consequences of forgiving one's father	Physical health 3/10		And I also feel that I'm less tired all the time, my quality of life, even physically, is completely different.	VR
	Mental health 9/10	Freedom 7/10	I feel complete freedom in life, I can live the life I want and if I hadn't forgiven my father, I would never have come to this feeling and this opportunity.	T
		Balance 6/10	I feel balance in my life.	
		Overall satisfaction 5/10	I see that I enjoy life more, I enjoy developing more, as if it affects not only my relationship	

Table 6 (continued)

	Categories	Subcategories	Representative statements	TC
	Personality change 9/10	Inner peace 5/10	with my father or my relationship with me, but also all the other things that concern me.	
		Self-acceptance, self-esteem 7/10	I finally feel inner peace.	T
		Growth 5/10	I'm not afraid of failure so much, I know who I am and I appreciate where I've come from in spite of everything.	
	Social benefits 9/10	Improved relationships with other people 8/10	Overall, in terms of personality, you can't compare where I was and where I am now.	
		Improved relationship with the father 5/10	I don't think I could have the same relationship with others if I hadn't forgiven my father.	T
	Physical health 3/10		Especially in relation to him, we have a completely different relationship now, and I can't imagine we would be like that if I hadn't forgave him for all of it.	
			Even physically, I don't feel that constant fatigue anymore, I sometimes felt I couldn't even get out of bed, so all those feelings bothered me.	VR

Note: TC = typology of categories; G = general; T = typical; VR = variable. Participant responses translated by team members from Slovak into English.

Table 7

Domain – Differences between forgiving one's mother and one's father.

	Category	Representative statements	TC
Differences between forgiving one's mother and one's father	More difficult with my father 6/10	it was very difficult in regard to my father. I fought it much more than I did with my mother.	T
	More difficult with my mother 2/10	It was a thorny path with my mother, it can't be compared to my father.	VR
	Did not feel any differences 2/10	No, I don't see any differences. Overall, forgiving both was hard and demanding work.	VR

Note: TC = typology of categories; G = general; T = typical; VR = variant. Participant responses translated by team members from Slovak into English.

The third category was a *positive change in personality*, and contained two subcategories. The three participants stated that because they had forgiven their father, their *self-esteem*, *self-value*, improved, and one participant commented on their *ability to have a healthy relationship*.

The last category relating to the two participants was a *change in their perception of relationships and the opposite sex*. One participant said she came to realize that not all men think like her father and the other participant said he learnt that he could build a healthy relationship full

Table 8

Domain – Association between the current romantic relationship and forgiving one's mother.

	Categories	Subcategories	Representative statements	TC
Relationship Association between current romantic relationship and forgiving one's mother	Positive change in aspects of the relationship 10/10 (G)	Satisfaction 5/10	I see overall satisfaction in the relationship, it's natural for me to kiss or hug, it wasn't natural for my parents.	T
		Understanding one's partner 4/10	So I try to understand and look at things through her eyes. I would probably have had a hard time handling it if I hadn't understood my mother. And mainly if I hadn't forgiven her.	VR
		Openness, honesty 4/10	The relationship is more honest, more open, I don't keep my feelings to myself.	VR
	Positive change in personality 6/10	Self-esteem, self-value 5/10 Ability to have a healthy relationship 1/10	I understood that I have value. I wouldn't be able to have a healthy relationship...	T
	Positive change in emotions reflected in the relationship 6/10 (T)		I know very well how my anger toward my mother blocked me and the relationship took on a completely different dimension after forgiveness. Our conversations are more about depth than about superficiality. I definitely owe it to everything I went through with my mother.	T
	Self-regulation 3/10 (VR)		I'm a completely different person, less explosive, calmer, more prudent.	VR

Note: TC = typology of categories; G = general; T = typical; VR = variant. Participant responses translated by team members from Slovak into English.

of trust and that it did not have to be just about anger, hatred or fear.

Typical cases of forgiving one's mother and forgiving one's father in adults raised in children's homes.

Next, we present typical examples of forgiving one's mother and forgiving one's father, following the recommendation by Hill and Knox (2021) that typical examples should be created from the most numerous categories in the research results.

The first typical case in our research is a man who was motivated to forgive his mother mainly because of conversations with staff at the children's home and with the volunteers who supported him throughout. Another important factor was the long-term exhaustion associated with constantly having negative feelings, such as anger or hatred. He decided to start working on forgiveness partly because he came to understand the true meaning of forgiveness, e.g. by

Table 9

Domain – Association between current romantic relationship and forgiving one's father.

	Categories	Subcategories	Representative statements	TC
Connection Association between current romantic relationship and forgiving one's father	Positive change in aspects of the relationship 8/10	Open communication 5/10	...my partner and I talk about everything, and there is definitely more openness and sincerity in the way I communicate.	T
		Satisfaction 4/10	...overall, I'm much happier with my partner, without forgiveness it probably wouldn't be possible.	
		Effort 3/10	The fact that I fight for my relationship and I'm not giving up is a consequence of forgiving my father.	
		Trust 2/10	If I hadn't forgiven my father, I wouldn't be able to trust my partner, his words, promises, in general, I would question everything he says.	
		Authenticity in a relationship 2/10	... being in a relationship myself, authentic and open, which therefore greatly affects my and my partner's satisfaction.	
	Positive change in emotions, not projecting the hurt onto a partner 8/10		If I hadn't forgiven, I would just worry, I would torment myself and I would project it all onto the relationship.	T
	Positive change in personality 4/10	Self-esteem, self-value 3/10	Forgiveness has taught me that I am strong and that I can do whatever I am able to. It taught me to love myself.	VR
	Change in perception of relationships and the opposite sex 2/10	The ability to have a healthy relationship 1/10	I don't think I would have a healthy relationship if I hadn't forgiven my father.	
			Forgiving my father gave me a completely different view of relationships, that you can live differently, that I just understand his situation, but my relationship	VR

(continued on next page)

Table 9 (continued)

Categories	Subcategories	Representative statements	TC
		with my partner doesn't have to look like that and that I don't have to end up like that.	

Note: TC = typology of categories; G = general; T = typical; VR = variant. Participant responses translated by team members from Slovak into English.

distinguishing forgiveness and reconciliation. In the initial stages of forgiving, it was important for him to understand his mother and everything she had been through, as well as the true meaning of forgiveness and his own feelings. Subsequently, it was easier for him to decide to forgive. Although initially he did so only mechanically and did not identify internally with it. He thought the main factors preventing him from forgiving were his negative feelings toward his mother, her disinterest, his own stubbornness and inability to stop feeling self-pity and his victim status. However, working with his emotions, he was able to forgive and can see that it has improved his life, especially his mental health. He feels much more balanced and satisfied, he has found inner peace, freedom and he does not have negative feelings toward his mother. He also thinks his personality has changed and that he benefits socially. He stated that there was a connection between forgiving his mother was his current romantic relationship, mainly positive changes in aspects of the relationship, a positive change in his personality, but also a positive change in his emotions, which is projected onto his relationship.

The second typical case is a woman who was motivated into forgiving her father mainly through conversations with staff at the children's home and volunteers. She was also tired of having negative feelings and a change in her perception of what forgiveness meant helped her to forgive. The most important thing for her at the beginning of the process was coming to understand her father and his life situation and why he behaved the way he did. As soon as she began working on forgiveness, she could see the benefits for her life, but she found forgiving him a struggle. She thinks her own stubbornness and self-pity were factors preventing her from forgiving her father and, in contrast to forgiving her mother, she thinks her father's lack of pity and justification were the key factors preventing her from forgiving him. It was also difficult for her to cope with the feelings of anger she harbored toward her father. In the end, however, forgiving her father had a positive impact on her life, especially in mental health terms, and she felt free, balanced, and that she had overall life satisfaction. She also thinks her personality change is important, especially in terms of self-esteem. The social benefits include better relationships with other people. She thinks that forgiving her father is reflected in her current romantic relationship, in the positive changes to aspects of the relationship, especially the open communication and her emotions, as she no longer projects her hurt onto her partner.

4. Discussion

4.1. Understanding of forgiveness among adults raised in children's homes

Our first partial aim was to examine what the term forgiveness meant to adults raised in children's homes (Q1). The results show that the adults in our research generally described the concept of forgiveness in much the same way as it is defined in the literature – as including an emotional, a cognitive, and a behavioral component (Enright, 2001). Out of these three components, the emotional component (absence of negative emotions and letting go of pain) was present the most, followed by the cognitive component. Participants mainly associated forgiveness with a decline in negative feelings, with moving forward and letting go

of all the painful emotions and bad things that had happened to them in their life. In fact, previous qualitative research has similarly found that individuals who have been hurt in a relationships mostly associate forgiveness with letting go of anger, resentment, or other painful emotions and memories (e.g. Freedman & Chang, 2010; Záhorcová & Zelenáková, 2021).

One aspect of forgiveness on which scholars disagree is whether positive feelings develop toward the one who hurt us (Exline et al., 2003; Rye et al., 2001). In our research, the adults reported the presence of positive experiences, but these were associated with their own balance, freedom and peace in life, which tend to be consequences of forgiving – they did not mention holding positive emotions toward the offender. We consider this finding important, as it indicates that such individuals may not develop positive emotions toward the offender, especially if the adult had been badly hurt by their parent. Therefore, we think that counselors and therapists need to understand that even though the individual may form positive emotions toward the offender over time and through working on the process of forgiveness, such emotions do not seem to be a necessary component of forgiving among adults raised in children's homes; reducing anger and resentment may have healing potential for clients.

On the cognitive level, the absence of repetitive thoughts proved to be important for six participants. In the literature, the definition of forgiveness does not directly refer to the absence of repetitive thoughts; however, research shows that higher forgiving is related to lower ruminations (Contreras et al., 2021). McCullough et al. (1998) even state that these constant intrusive thoughts inhibit forgiveness and prevent us from developing empathy for the person who has hurt us and therefore act as a block on forgiveness. On the other hand, forgiving may help us to free ourselves of burdensome repetitive thoughts relating to the transgression and offender (Enright, 2001) and enable us to live more in the present moment.

In our research, three adults defined forgiveness as involving understanding the other person and accepting the situation and all the bad things that happened. Even though scholars define acceptance as being part of the process of forgiving rather than forgiveness itself (Worthington, 2008), acceptance was the the most common definition of forgiveness among bereaved parents (Záhorcová et al., 2020). This may indicate that serious harm may be directly linked to the need for individuals to accept an unchangeable situation.

On the behavioral level, half of the participants mentioned a reduced desire for revenge, which McCullough (2000) considers to be the main component of forgiveness and may be connected to an inner change in emotions and cognitions toward the offender. Overall, it seems that in adults raised in children's homes the emotional component of forgiving is present most, followed by the cognitive one. It is therefore possible that forgiving, especially such a deep relational hurt as being abandoned by one's parent, mostly occurs through internal work, which takes place inside the person on the emotional and cognitive level.

4.2. Forgiving one's mother and father and differences in forgiveness

Our second partial aim was to examine forgiveness toward one's mother (Q2) and forgiveness toward one's father (Q3) and analyze any potential differences in forgiving one's parents (Q4).

It was almost impossible for the adults in our research to distinguish their motivation to forgive their mother and father. Interviews with the children's home staff and volunteers proved to be most important. This finding also supports other research findings that highlight the importance of relationships with the staff of children's homes (Harris et al., 2008) as well as the importance of having mentors, in our case volunteers, who care for the children and provide individual guidance (Liu et al., 2022). The adults also felt exhausted by negative feelings, such as anger or hatred, and saw that as a motivational factor for forgiveness. Counselors and therapists who work with adults raised in children's homes could therefore be recommended to ask their clients if

experiencing negative emotions toward their parent(s) tires them out – which is one of the steps in the forgiveness intervention curriculum developed by Enright (2001). At the same time, working on forgiving the offender, in this case a parent, may in itself help decrease anger, hatred, or symptoms of depression, anxiety, and posttraumatic stress disorder, while increasing self-esteem and hope, as has been extensively shown in previous research studies testing the effects of forgiveness therapy in various populations (e.g. Akhtar & Barlow, 2018; Reed & Enright, 2006). Therefore, we recommend that future research test an experimental forgiveness intervention involving children placed in children's homes, or adults raised in children's homes, and monitor its effects on forgiveness and mental health.

In our research the adults found the process of forgiving either their mother or father demanding and long. They stressed that before forgiving both parents they first had to understand them, their life situation and why they had been unable to care for them. This research finding is consistent with research by Enright (2001) and Worthington (2008), who emphasized that one of the main steps in forgiveness is to develop understanding, empathy and compassion for the offender, to think about what the offender went through as a child and what they went through at the time of the harm. This should enable them to understand the situation better and develop forgiveness (but not justify the offender's actions). Equally important was understanding what forgiveness is and their own feelings. According to Rizkalla et al. (2008), forgiveness requires the person first to be aware of their own emotions and then to regulate and control those emotions. Moreover, the adults stated that they decided to forgive both parents, and that this decision was initially mechanical and inside they did not feel that they had truly forgiven their parents. Linked to this, Worthington (2005) defines two types of forgiveness: decisional forgiveness and emotional forgiveness – but in decisional forgiveness negative emotions do not necessarily become positive ones, which is what our research shows too.

Among the factors that helped the adults to forgive both parents was coming to understand their mother's and father's situations and lives. They found this challenging. We therefore think that forgiveness therapy could play an important role in the lives of children placed in children's homes. It could significantly help them forgive their parents, as one of the steps in this process is the ability to understand the person who hurt us (Enright, 2001). Adults in the process of forgiving their mother stated that they had written her a letter that they never sent, but that writing it had been very helpful to them, as they could watch how their feelings changed over time and see what they still had to work on. Writing letters forms an important part of forgiveness in several models (Baskin & Enright, 2004; McCullough & Worthington, 1995). As it proved very helpful to the adults in our research, it would be good to emphasize letter writing more in counseling or therapy when assisting clients who have been significantly hurt by their parents.

The more serious the wrongdoing or betrayal is – typically associated with many negative emotions – and the more one considers the other person to be fully responsible for what happened, the more difficult it is to forgive (Freedman & Chang, 2010; Záhorcová & Zelenáková, 2021). The results of our research confirm that the most important factors preventing adults from forgiving their parents are negative feelings toward both parents, such as anger and hatred, and feelings of guilt and injustice. Another important factor was disinterest from the mother or father. Five participants stated that it was difficult for them to stop pitying themselves and feeling like a victim. In fact, research shows that individuals who have a higher tendency to feel like a victim in interpersonal relationships are less willing to forgive others and are more likely to seek revenge (Gabay et al., 2020). Stubbornness is closely related to feeling like a victim, which was the case for half of the adults in our research. We agree with Baumeister et al. (1998), who state that stubbornness and continuing to feel like a victim reinforce the negative emotions associated with betrayal or wrongdoing. When working with this target group, we therefore consider it important for the person to focus on processing and discovering their own emotions, especially since

the adults often did not even know what they felt or why they felt it. As confirmed by Enright & Fitzgibbons (2015), the person may need help understanding that not forgiving is linked to various physical or mental difficulties caused by suppressed anger. However, it is important to state that those working through their painful emotions must do so in a safe environment. A safe environment could be a counselor or therapist who connects empathetically with the client.

The consequences of forgiveness were particularly felt in mental health. The research supports our findings that forgiveness plays an important role in reducing mental stress, symptoms of anxiety and depression, as well as resentment caused by betrayal or wrongdoing (Akhtar & Barlow, 2018). Forgiveness also improves mental well-being, which is characterized by greater life satisfaction (Eldeléklioglu, 2015), as reported by the adults in our research. Another consequence of forgiveness was personality change, where forgiving the mother was mainly connected to openness, better regulation of emotions and self-acceptance, while forgiving the father was mainly connected to self-esteem and personal growth. However, Day & Padilla-Walker (2009) stated in their research that a person's relationship with their mother promotes empathy and self-acceptance, and their relationship with the father promotes better regulation of emotions. The difference may be down to the sex of the adult. As we did not address gender differences in our research, it would be interesting in future research to focus on whether there is a relationship between the sex of the adult and personality changes.

Regarding the differences in forgiveness toward one's parents, most of the adults stated that it was more difficult for them to forgive their father, as their relationship with him was "broken", and they perceived this as a major obstacle to forgiving. This difference in forgiving one's mother versus one's father was also seen in the fact that although some adults were able to reconcile with their mothers, none of the adults mentioned reconciliation with their father. This difference may be down to the fact that, as Kenrick et al. (2004) point out, being separated from one's children is often easier for a father than for a mother, which is consistent with the evolutionary theory of gender differences. As a result, it may be relatively easy for fathers to be less engaged in their relationship with their children and therefore they may be less effective at working on forgiveness in their relationships with their children. With regard to these findings, we think it important to focus on strengthening parenting skills in fathers when working with families, because even though the adults mentioned having a worse relationship with their father than with their mother, they spoke of a strong need to have their father in their lives.

4.3. Relationship between participants' current romantic relationship and forgiving their parents

As our last partial aim, we examined the relationship between the participants' current romantic relationship and forgiving their parents (Q5, Q6).

The adults stated that there was a connection between their current romantic relationship and forgiving their parents as they felt there had been a positive change in aspects of their relationship and personality. They started to see their own value and stated that they were able to have a healthy relationship, which they could not have done had they not forgiven their parents. Our findings are consistent with other research (Reed & Enright, 2006) that states that the perceived benefits of forgiveness often include an awareness of one's inner strengths and self-esteem.

Previous research has also shown that forgiveness benefits the person's social life as it helps mend relationships (e.g. Gordon, 2003). This is supported by our research results: six adults reported a positive change in their emotions that was reflected in relationship satisfaction. Also, two adults said there had been a change in their perception of relationships and the opposite sex, which is indicative of internal healing and subsequent trust building in relationships.

Regarding the connection with forgiving the mother, the adults also reported better self-regulation, that they were much less short-tempered or aggressive. This is supported by research findings by Morris et al. (2007) that indicate that a close parent–child relationship is important for the development of emotional regulation. In our research, we consider forgiveness to play an important role in the creation of a close relationship with parents, which may also result in appropriate self-regulation in a romantic relationship.

4.4. Limitations and future research

We are aware that there are some limitations in our work. Although small research groups are typical of the CQR method, the downside is that the results cannot be generalized to the entire population of adults raised in children's homes. Given the limitation regarding the sample size, we were unable to explore gender differences in adult women and men forgiving their mothers and fathers. We did, however, find some differences compared to previous research in personality change resulting from forgiving one's mother versus one's father. It is therefore possible that the sex of the adult may be a factor influencing the different forgiveness patterns regarding the mother and the father. Future research could explore this issue using quantitative methods and a larger sample size.

Another limitation is the use of individual interviews as the only method of data collection. In future research the use of other data collection methods, such as focus groups, should be considered as participants would have more of an opportunity to communicate their experiences and ideas.

In addition, since we specifically explored associations between forgiving one's parents and current heterosexual romantic relationships in adults raised in children's homes, it may be important to further investigate the nuances of forgiveness in adults choosing not to enter into a romantic relationship or in those in same-sex relationships.

5. Conclusions

Our research has produced some useful findings. We have shed more light on experiences of forgiveness in adults raised in children's homes, which is an area that has attracted little research so far. The results also highlight the importance of forgiveness therapy, which should be provided to children when placed in children's homes as this could minimize the impact on their mental health and subsequent relationships. The participants pointed out some important motivating factors and steps that helped them to forgive, which may prove helpful to professionals working with children and adolescents in children's homes or adults raised in children's homes. These factors mainly related to having meaningful conversations with staff at the children's home and volunteers. Such conversations helped the participants to recognize their hurt feelings and to understand what forgiveness means, e.g. to distinguish between forgiveness and pardon the hurt or reconciliation with the offender. Also, obtaining a better understanding of their parents, their situation and their life was a key motivation for adults seeking to forgive their parents. Therefore, counselors or therapists could provide a safe environment and guide these individuals through processing their emotions and working on developing empathy and compassion for their parents, but not condoning their actions. Last but not least, the exhaustion stemming from negative feelings proved to be an important motivational factor in forgiving parents.

Adults raised in children's homes who forgave their parents found that the main outcome was better mental health, especially the absence of negative feelings and the attainment of inner peace. However, achieving these positive results required them to go through a long and often painful process of forgiving. The overall process of forgiving one's mother and father was very similar for the adults. However, there were some differences in perceptions of the overall difficulty of forgiving, with the adults finding it more difficult to forgive their father because

their relationship with him was more difficult.

In relation to parental forgiveness and romantic relationship, the adults talked especially of positive changes in aspects of the relationship, such as greater satisfaction, more open communication, and being more understanding of their partner. Also, forgiving their parent decreased their tendency to project their hurt feelings onto their partner.

Overall, the research results point to the importance of forgiveness in the lives of adults raised in children's homes, and they described it as a necessary factor in healing the relationship with their parents. We believe that it is important that children's homes focus on forgiveness therapy so the disrupted child–parent relationship has a minimal effect on their adult life and relationships. The parents of children in children's homes often have their own history of being placed in institutional care. Therefore we think that if the relationships with their parents can be healed through forgiveness (not necessarily in conjunction with reconciliation), these adults would have a better chance of forming healthy relationships and families, and that could stop the generational cycle of children being placed in institutional care.

Declaration of Competing Interest

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Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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